REC145 Program Plan – Rough Draft
Group: Group 6
Program Title: The Escape Within: Mindfulness Retreat Room
Topic: Stress Management and Mindfulness
Target Population: Youth ages 12+
Facilitation Technique: Interactive activities, teamwork, and group discussion
Estimated Time: 35–40 minutes

Statement of Purpose

The purpose of our program is to help youth learn different ways to manage stress and practise mindfulness in a fun and interactive way. Instead of just talking about stress management, we want participants to actually try different techniques through an online escape room.
The escape room will have different rooms with activities that focus on breathing, emotions, negative thoughts, and letting go of stress. Participants will work in teams to complete the challenges and come together at the end to solve one final puzzle.

Program Goal

Our goal is to help youth learn and practise different mindfulness and stress-management techniques through a fun online escape room.
We also want participants to understand how they can use these techniques in their everyday lives when they are feeling stressed or overwhelmed.

Program Objectives

Objective 1: By the end of the escape room, participants will be able to practise at least two mindfulness or stress-management techniques through the activities.
Objective 2: By the end of the program, participants will be able to name at least one mindfulness technique they learned and explain how they could use it in their everyday life.

Content and Process

1. Preparation

Before starting the program, we will make sure the website works properly and that participants can access it on their computers.
We will also:

- Test the different escape-room activities.
- Make sure the website link works.
- Divide participants into smaller teams.
- Explain how the game will work.
- Prepare a timer and reflection questions.
- Make sure everyone knows how to communicate with their team.

2. Introduction (5 minutes)

- We will start by welcoming everyone and introducing our topic, which is stress management and mindfulness.
- We will briefly explain what mindfulness means and how it can help people become more aware of their thoughts and feelings.
- Then, we will introduce our online escape room called *The Escape Within*.
- We will explain that participants will go through different rooms, and each room will have a challenge related to mindfulness.
- Participants will work with their teams to solve the challenges and unlock the next room.
- At the end, everyone will need to work together to solve one final puzzle.
- We will remind participants that the goal is to have fun, learn new techniques, and work together.

3. Active Engagement / Main Activity (25–30 minutes)

Our main activity will be an online escape room with five different rooms.
Each room will teach participants a different way to manage stress or practise mindfulness.

Room 1: The Breathing Chamber
Activity: Breathe With Brain Buddy

In this room, participants will meet a cute little brain character called Brain Buddy.
Brain Buddy will guide participants through a breathing exercise.
The character will slowly get bigger when participants are supposed to breathe in and smaller when they breathe out.
Participants will follow the character for a few breathing cycles.
Once the breathing activity is finished, they can move to the next room.

Purpose: To teach participants a simple breathing technique they can use when they are feeling stressed.

Room 2: The Emotion Gallery
Activity: Draw Your Emotions

In this room, participants will use a digital drawing board to draw what an emotion looks like to them.
They will be given prompts such as:

- Draw what happiness looks like to you.
- Draw what calmness looks like to you.
- Draw what sadness looks like to you.
- Draw what frustration looks like to you.

Participants can use different colours and shapes to express their emotions.
There are no right or wrong answers.

After completing their drawing, they can unlock the next room.
Purpose: To help participants recognize their emotions and express how they feel through art.

Room 3: The Weight of Words
Activity: Breaking Negative Thoughts
In this room, participants will see a large wall blocking their way.
The wall will be made of bricks with different negative or stressful thoughts written on them.
Some examples include:

- "I'm not good enough."
- "I'm going to fail."
- "Everyone is judging me."
- "I have to be perfect."

Participants will click on the bricks and answer questions about the thoughts.
For example, if a brick says "I'm going to fail," participants will need to choose a healthier way of looking at that thought.
One possible answer could be:
"I'm having the thought that I might fail, but that doesn't mean it will actually happen."
When they choose the correct answer, the brick will break and disappear.
Once all the bricks are removed, the door will open.

Purpose: To teach participants that just because we think something negative does not mean it is true.

Room 4: The Release Garden
Activity: Letting Go of Stress
In this room, participants will enter a peaceful digital garden with flowers, trees, and stars.
There will be a text box where participants can type something that is stressing them out.
They can also use a made-up example if they do not want to share anything personal.
After typing their thought, they will click a button that says "Release."
Their words will slowly disappear and turn into stars floating into the sky.
After that, participants will answer a short question about how to handle a stressful situation.
For example:
"You have a lot of assignments due and are feeling overwhelmed. What could you do?"
Participants will choose the best response, such as taking a short break, breathing, and making a plan.
Once they answer, they can move to the final room.

Purpose: To help participants understand that it is okay to experience stressful thoughts and that they can take a moment to pause before responding.

Room 5: The Unity Vault
Activity: The Final Escape
This will be the final challenge where everyone needs to work together.
Each participant will receive a different secret word or clue on their screen.
For example:

- Person 1: PAUSE
- Person 2: BREATHE
- Person 3: NOTICE
- Person 4: RELEASE
- Person 5: CONNECT

Participants will have to communicate with each other to figure out the correct order of the words.
The words will create a final secret phrase that unlocks the vault.
The important part is that no one person will have the full answer. Everyone will need to share their clue to complete the challenge.
Once they enter the correct phrase, the vault will open and everyone will successfully escape.
Purpose: To encourage teamwork, communication, and problem-solving while reviewing the mindfulness ideas learned throughout the game.

4. Closure / Reflection (5–10 minutes)
After everyone finishes the escape room, we will bring participants back together for a short discussion.
We will ask questions based on the *What? So What? Now What?* reflection method.
What?

- What was your favourite room?
- Which activity did you enjoy the most?
- What mindfulness techniques did you learn?

So What?

- How did you feel while completing the activities?
- Did any activity help you feel calmer or more relaxed?
- What did you learn about negative thoughts?

Now What?

- Which mindfulness technique would you use again?
- How could you use these techniques when you are stressed at school or at home?
- What is one thing you will take away from this activity?

We will end by reminding participants that stress is something everyone experiences and that there are different ways to manage it.
5. Post-Tasks
After the activity, we will talk as a group about how the program went.
We will look at what worked well, what participants enjoyed, and what we could improve.

We will also discuss whether participants were able to understand and practise the mindfulness techniques.

Implementation Description

Target Population

Our program is for youth ages 12 and older.

We chose an escape-room format because we want the activity to feel more like a game instead of a lesson.

The activities will include colourful graphics, interactive puzzles, and teamwork to keep participants engaged.

Preparation for Facilitators

Before running the activity, we will:

- Make sure the website is working.
- Test the website on different devices.
- Prepare the teams.
- Explain the instructions clearly.
- Have backup activities ready in case the website does not work.
- Make sure everyone has a chance to participate.

Risk Management

Some participants might not feel comfortable talking about their stress or emotions.

We will make it clear that they do not have to share anything personal and can use made-up examples.

We will also remind everyone to be respectful of each other.

For the breathing activity, participants can follow at their own pace.

If the website stops working, we can still explain the challenges and complete some of the activities through group discussion.

We also want to make sure that the competition does not become stressful, so we will focus more on having fun and working together than on winning.

Materials and Equipment

- Computers or laptops
- Internet access
- Escape-room website
- Brain Buddy character
- Digital drawing board
- Timer
- Zoom, Microsoft Teams, or another platform for communication
- Optional paper and pencils

Evaluation Plan

Evaluating the Quality of the Program

At the end of the activity, we will ask participants a few questions to see if they enjoyed the program.

Some questions could include:

- Did you enjoy the escape room?
- Which room was your favourite?
- Was the activity easy to understand?
- What would you change about the game?

We will also observe whether participants were engaged and working together.

Evaluating the Program Outcomes

To see if we reached our objectives, we will look at whether participants were able to complete the mindfulness challenges.

We will also use the reflection questions at the end to see if participants can name at least one mindfulness technique and explain how they could use it in real life.